THE NAXAL RETREAT

The claim marks a dramatic shift from a conflict that, at its peak about 15 years ago, spanned 12 states and affected nearly 200 million people residing in this swathe known as the Red Corridor. In Bastar alone, long considered its epicentre, around 6,000 sq. km of area remained outside effective state control as recently as December 2023, with parallel systems of taxation and justice enforced by insurgents.

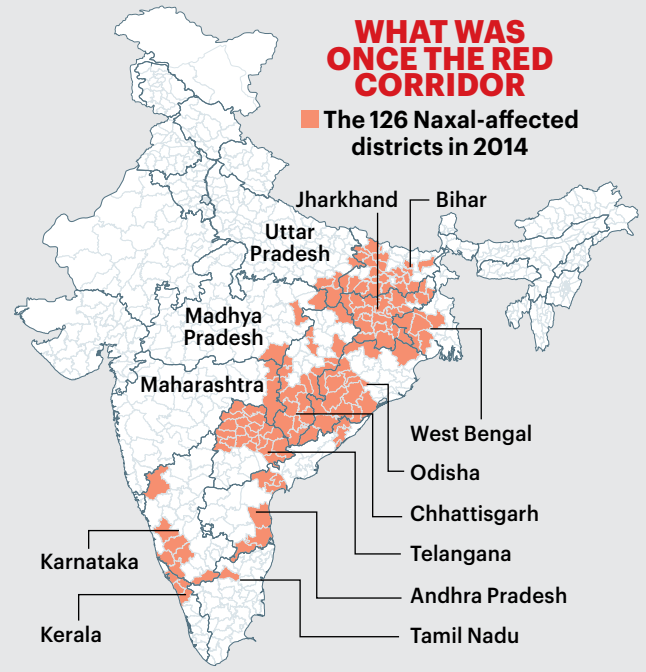
That geography has since contracted sharply. According to figures shared by Shah, the number of LWE-affected districts has fallen from 126 in 2014 to just two, while the 'most-affected' districts are down to zero from 35. Though he did not name the remaining affected districts, recent developments point to Narayanpur and Bijapur in Bastar. More importantly, security agencies now describe the insurgency as a fragmented, localised threat.

In Bastar, Inspector General (IG) P. Sundarraj estimates that only 20–25 armed Naxals remain, many operating as lone wolves. In Jharkhand, the residual presence is confined to small forested pockets in the Saranda–Kolhan belt of West Singhbhum. Gadcharoli, once the hub of Naxalism in Maharashtra, has just six Naxals on record, of which one is a local and the rest are from Chhattisgarh, where all are suspected to be hiding right now. In Andhra Pradesh, Director General of Police (DGP) Harish Kumar Gupta says the movement's "underground cadre strength has been reduced to zero".

Leadership attrition has been decisive. The CPI (Maoist)'s top leadership—its politburo and central committee (CC)—has been systematically dismantled through arrests, surrenders and encounters. From five politburo members and 19 other CC members in December 2023, the leadership has shrunk to just two politburo members. Of the two, 72-year-old Muppala Lakshmana Rao, alias Ganapathy, is believed to be unwell, possibly in Nepal. The other, Misir Besra, 65, remains active in Jharkhand but no longer able to organise cadres beyond a limited area.

0
No. of districts most affected by Naxalism in 2026, down from 35 in 2014

2
No. of districts affected by Naxalism in 2026, down from 126 in 2014



SINCE 2024

706	2,218	4,839
Naxals killed	Naxals arrested	Naxals surrendered

> **"NAXALISM IS NOW ON THE VERGE OF EXTINCTION. THE COUNTRY WILL BE INFORMED ONCE THE ENTIRE PROCESS IS FORMALLY COMPLETED. BUT I CAN SAY THAT WE HAVE BECOME NAXAL-FREE"**
>
> **AMIT SHAH,** *Union Home Minister, in Parliament on Mar. 30*

The government attributes this outcome to a three-pronged strategy: sustained security operations, an aggressive surrender and rehabilitation policy, and a parallel development push.

THREE-PRONGED STRATEGY

First, force. The shift became sharper after December 2023, when a change in government in Chhattisgarh was followed by a visibly more proactive operational posture. Security forces began launching deeper, sustained offensives into core Maoist zones, signalling what officials describe as a "no-holds-barred" approach. "There are times when operations result in collateral damage. But once the local commander realises that no questions are going to be asked, the risk-taking ability increases," a Bastar-based police officer told INDIA TODAY. The approach, however, has also raised questions of accountability. In Parliament, Shah emphasised that "those who fire bullets will be answered with bullets", while keeping the door to dialogue open for those willing to surrender.

Meanwhile, intelligence-gathering was transformed through the use of technology: drones, satellite imagery and AI-based data analysis. A coordinated, multi-agency effort—bringing together the National Investigation Agency, Enforcement Directorate, Intelligence Bureau and state intelligence units—sought to choke Maoist finances